

The Privileges and Restrictions of my Personal Cultural Identity

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My cultural identity is a complex tapestry woven from various social identities, each contributing to how I experience the world. From my privileges in race and age to the hindrances that my gender identity and social status provide, all of these factors intersect to shape my experiences as both a target and an agent group member.

Race

As a white individual, I benefit from numerous privileges associated with my racial identity. These privileges manifest in subtle yet impactful ways, granting me easier access to opportunities and reducing the likelihood of facing racial discrimination. This privilege does not absolve me from the responsibility of acknowledging the systemic inequities that perpetuate the oppression that people of other races face. I recognize that my racial identity can afford me advantages and that I must, therefore, navigate this identity with sensitivity and awareness for others.

Sex and Gender

Legally and medically, I am classified as male, which typically conveys privilege and would align me with the agent group. However, my gender identity as a transgender/genderqueer woman complicates this narrative perception. While being perceived as a woman can lead to some overt expressions of sexism, I more frequently face significant challenges related to my transgender identity. Even in professional settings, I have encountered derogatory remarks—such as being referred to as “Manabelle” behind my back—that highlight the prejudice I endure. There are still those that perceive me as male. In my personal life, many members of my family refuse to accept my identity, and many academic and legal environments assume I’m male unless otherwise confronted. This gives me advantages for things like job application considerations or

navigating complex situations where I am able to remain semi-anonymous—such as phone calls and emails. This duality of privilege and oppression underscores the complexities of my experience in navigating my gender and sexual identities.

Sexual Orientation

My sexual orientation adds another layer of complexity to my identity. I identify as bisexual, asexual, and polyamorous, and I frequently find myself marginalized both outside and within the LGBTQ+ community. For instance, I am often criticized for my bisexuality, facing accusations of not being "gay enough" or "too gay" or of failing to "choose a side." My asexuality is met with skepticism, as some view it as invalid or not real. Additionally, my polyamorous relationships invite scrutiny and misunderstanding. Many find it difficult to understand my views, or view it as cheating. These attacks contribute to a sense of alienation and highlight the unique challenges I face within the community.

Social Status and Class

My upbringing in a lower-middle-class family significantly shaped my perspective on social class. Growing up in a neighborhood which was characterized by economic disparity instilled in me a strong awareness of social stratification. My parents worked tirelessly, balancing full-time jobs and a side business, yet financial stability remained inaccessible, leaving us with few luxuries. After being outed, I was forced to leave my home, relying on my now-spouse for support to secure housing. Presently, I still continue to navigate life as a member of the working class, often living paycheck to paycheck, which impacts my sense of security and opportunity.

Religion

My religious identity further complicates my narrative. Raised in a Christian household,

my perceived actions and identities eventually led to my estrangement from my parents, who viewed my life choices as sinful and kicked me out. In contrast to how I was raised, I identify as an agnostic pagan, embracing the notion of a higher power without adherence to a specific doctrine. I strive to uphold the core Christian values of love and kindness that I was taught, though I do not align myself with any particular sect. This divergence has created a complex relationship with my past and beliefs, and has allowed me to navigate my relationships with others of various faiths with an open mind.

Ability and Disability

While I may appear able-bodied, I live with both physical and mental disabilities. My heart conditions pose risks, including fainting spells and dizziness, which can hinder my ability to concentrate. Furthermore, I navigate several mental health challenges, including autism, DID, ADHD, anxiety, and depression, alongside minor dyslexia. These disabilities often influence my daily functioning and effect the way I interact with the world. Navigating with invisible disabilities has helped me better empathize with others, leading me to not assume when confronted with others who may appear able-bodied.

Age

At 24, my age significantly influences how I am perceived, especially in professional contexts. According to the Matrix of Oppression, I belong to a targeted class due to my age. However, my life experiences have fostered a maturity that often causes others to see me as older. While this perception can offer certain advantages, it also imposes pressure, as I am frequently held to standards that exceed those typically expected of my peers. This discrepancy can lead to conflict when I act in ways more reflective of my actual age, which has been an issue since I was 16.

Awareness

Reflecting on my identities reveals a nuanced understanding of how they shape my lived experiences. While I am acutely aware of these identities in a reflective context, I often find that many aspects fade into the background in everyday life. My gender identity and sex come to the forefront in situations such as public restrooms or when facing confrontation. Similarly, my disabilities become prominent when they impede my ability to function, particularly in academic settings. In contrast, my race, social status, religion, and age remain less prominent in my daily considerations. These identities typically surface during discussions or when I am directly targeted because of them. It is often easier to overlook these aspects unless they demand my attention due to external circumstances. This awareness—or lack thereof—highlights the intricate interplay of privilege and oppression that shapes my identity.

Responses to Triggers

My typical responses to triggers involving my targeted groups are avoidance, withdrawal, and silence. These reactions stem from the trauma of being raised in what could be considered an abusive household, where defending myself often resulted in accusations of backtalk and further consequences. However, recently I have started to advocate for myself more effectively, shifting towards a confrontational approach. While this strategy doesn't always produce positive outcomes, I generally reserve it as a last resort, particularly in situations marked by heightened hostility toward my identities. In contrast, my responses to triggers related to my agent groups often include silence or discussion. I believe that in my position of privilege I should not be the arbiter of perception, and instead should aim to foster understanding without overshadowing the voices of others.

Critical Incident Inventory

In reviewing the Critical Incident Inventory, I chose to reflect on a time when I supported and participated in oppressive behavior directed at members of my targeted social groups. As I was raised in a conservative Christian household, I grew up believing that certain groups, particularly those within the LGBTQ+ community, were living in sin and were detrimental to society. As I began to understand my own identity as part of these groups, I internalized these beliefs, rationalizing that I was different as long as I didn't act on my feelings. Later, in high school, I felt like an outcast and sought friendship with individuals who were harmful. While some of these friends were gay, they also held bigoted views, but because they didn't mind my queerness, I felt accepted by them, which allowed my internalized beliefs to persist. We often made jokes about gay people and casually used homophobic slurs, thinking it was funny. Over time, I have embraced my identity and now express it proudly. However, I have had to confront my past actions and acknowledge the harm I caused by targeting individuals both within and outside my own identities. This reflection has helped me dismantle my biases, understand their origins, and learn how to avoid them in the future.

